

Trump’s show: Movies, Alcatraz

White House offers no details on tariffs for foreign-made films or reopening landmark as a federal prison.

By MICHAEL WILNER

President Trump surprised California with a pair of announcements over the weekend to impose tariffs on films produced abroad and to reopen Alcatraz, a San Francisco landmark, as a working prison, all without consultation with state officials.

The White House would not offer details on either plan, perplexing industry executives and local lawmakers who see both as highly impractical, and prompting a series of basic questions that administration officials pressed by The Times were unprepared to answer.

How does Trump’s team plan to collect import duties on a product that amounts to intellectual property? Does the president’s team understand that most Hollywood productions are at least partially filmed overseas? And why is the federal government going to shut down a national historic landmark, reconverting it into a prison in the heart of a city after closing it 60 years ago due to skyrocketing costs?

Yet Trump’s focus on Hollywood, in particular, has gained him praise for drawing national attention to a growing crisis for Los Angeles, which is losing its prized industry at a concerning speed. Film executives aren’t asking whether the president’s intentions are in the right place. They are asking whether his solutions make any sense — or might backfire.

Trump’s announcement on film tariffs came after one of his three named ambassadors to Hollywood, Jon Voight, flew to the president’s Trump’s Mar-a-Lago resort in Florida over the [See California, A7]



JEFF PACHOUD AFP/Getty Images

THOUSANDS of people waited for hours in St. Peter’s Square after cardinals closed the door to the Sistine Chapel to begin the selection process. Black smoke from the chimney signaled no pope was chosen on Day One.

At Vatican, the wait begins

By NICOLE WINFIELD

VATICAN CITY — Black smoke poured out of the Sistine Chapel chimney on Wednesday, signaling that no pope had been elected as 133 cardinals opened the secretive, centuries-old ritual to choose a new leader of the Catholic Church.

The cardinals participating in the most geographically diverse conclave in the faith’s 2,000-year history took just one round of voting Wednesday evening. After failing to find a winner on the first ballot, they retired for the night and will return to the Sistine Chapel on Thursday morning to try to find a successor to Pope Francis.

They had opened the conclave Wednesday afternoon, participating in a rite more theatrical than even Hollywood could create, a wash of red-robed cardinals, Latin chants, incense and solemnity that underscored the seriousness of the moment.

Outside in St. Peter’s Basilica, the scene was festive, as thousands of people

Cardinals open their conclave to determine who will be the new pope, as crowds gather outside



Vatican Pool

A MASS was held in St. Peter’s Basilica before cardinals filed into the chapel, surrendering their phones.

flocked to the piazza to watch the proceedings on giant video screens, applauding when the Sistine Chapel’s doors slammed shut and the voting began. They waited for hours, watching screens that showed just a skinny chimney and the occasional seagull. After the vote dragged on to dinner-time, some left in frustration, but those who stayed cheered when the smoke finally billowed out.

“My hope is that cardinals will choose a man who can be a peacemaker and could reunify the church,” said Gabriel Capry, a 27-year-old from London.

Hailing from 70 countries, the cardinals were sequestered Wednesday from the outside world, their cellphones surrendered and airwaves around the Vatican jammed to prevent all communications until they find a new pope.

Cardinal Pietro Parolin, the secretary of state under Francis and himself a leading contender to become pope, assumed the leadership, [See Conclave, A4]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

A TRAVELER waits in a security line at John Wayne Airport in Orange County. Workers reported seeing more people with passports for U.S. flights than usual.

Real ID requirement elicits surprise but few holdups at Southland airports

By HANNAH FRY, ANDREW J. CAMPA AND KAITLYN HUAMANI

Travelers arriving at security checkpoints at Southern California airports on Wednesday were greeted with signs posing a pressing question: “Are you Real ID ready?”

After two decades of delays and government messaging, Wednesday marked Real ID deadline day for Americans who planned to board a domestic flight. Travelers are now required to show the federally compliant Real ID or another approved form of identification such as a passport to pass through airport security.

Those who flashed federally approved identification — aimed at enhancing security at airports nationwide — sailed through checkpoints without delay. Travelers without it faced a few hoops and, at times, a little bit of public embarrassment before they could board their flights.

[See Airports, A9]

Political promises aren’t enough to allay stress about finances

Cost of living remains top issue as California Democratic leaders work on their vows to address affordability.

By SANDRA McDONALD

SACRAMENTO — After voters in November sent a clear message that the rising cost of living remained a top concern, California lawmakers came to the Capitol vowing to take decisive action.

“Our task this session is urgent and clear,” Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas (D-Hollister) told lawmakers at the start of the 2024-25 legislative session in early December. “We must chart a new path forward. And it begins by focusing on affordability.”

Despite proposed legislation to help make California a more affordable place to live, however, voters in the state are growing increasingly pessimistic about their financial future, according to a new poll from the UC

Berkeley Institute of Governmental Studies, co-sponsored by The Times. Nearly half of California voters feel worse off than they were last year, and 54% felt less hopeful about their economic well-being.

When asked to name the most important issues for state leaders to be addressing this year, the cost of living, housing affordability and homelessness topped the list — far above concerns about crime and public safety, taxes and immigration, the poll found.

“The number one issue is an economic issue. It’s the cost of living,” Mark DiCamillo, director of the IGS poll, said. “Both Democrats and Republicans are in agreement on that one.”

Californians’ fears about their future, and their current financial well-being, dramatically increased after President Trump moved back into the White House in January, DiCamillo said. Within months, Trump announced sweeping new tariffs on goods imported from [See Affordability, A12]

A new way to guide post-fire rebuild

Commission proposes creating authorities to help homeowners, find funding, buy lots.

By IAN JAMES

An independent commission is calling for the creation of new local government authorities to oversee the rebuilding of fire-damaged neighborhoods in Altadena and Pacific Palisades, with powers to coordinate planning and construction efforts and secure financing from property taxes, state and federal funds, and philanthropic organizations.

The proposal is one of several preliminary recommendations in a report issued by the Blue Ribbon Commission on Climate Action and Fire-Safe Recovery, which was formed by Los Angeles County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath to help inform the recovery efforts.

“It’s really critical we provide homeowners and communities all the resources they can get to be able to afford to rebuild,” said Matt Petersen, the commission’s chair and chief executive of Los Angeles Cleantech Incubator, which works with startups to promote renewable energy. “It really provides us additional resources and finds ways to leverage capital to help.”

Fernando Guerra, director of the Center for the Study of Los Angeles at Loyola Marymount University, said that he thought the recommendations were good but that there were various practical hurdles to implementing them.

“They’re obviously easier said than done,” Guerra said. “They are all doable, but there needs to be political will to carry them out, and you need to have the buy-in of the property owners.”

The 20-member commission includes people drawn from business, local government, civic organizations and environmental groups, [See Rebuilding, A12]

Lawmakers fret over Medicaid

Republicans in Congress are scrambling to fulfill budget promises without gutting program. **NATION, A6**

Local island site is ‘endangered’

Preservation group lists last buildings of Japanese American fishing village. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Disney to build park in Mideast

Burbank company announces expansion into Abu Dhabi as it reports higher earnings. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 80/61. **B6**

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